autocratic. None of the charges stuck. The gang struck when Y J Rao transferred a woman, who was his personal assistant in Trivandrum, to SHAR.

When complaints against Y J Rao piled up, Dhawan constituted a committee to inquire. VSSC director Brahm Prakash, Gowarikar, Muthunayagam and ISRO chairman's advisor Y S Rajan were part of the committee. Later Rajan told me that the panel turned out to be a motley crowd of people, most of who had an axe to grind with Y J Rao.

Once when the discussions in the committee meeting degenerated to personal vilification of Y J Rao, Rajan walked out of it, never to return. Brahm Prakash, too, came out of the committee, calling it a 'gutter group'.

The committee submitted a report to the chairman recommending Y J Rao's transfer out of SHAR. Dhawan upheld the recommendation and transferred Y J Rao to the ISRO headquarters in Bangalore as the director, launch services. This post, occupied by Abdul Kalam for a short while before being moved to DRDL, thus came to be considered the 'exit route' from ISRO. Dhawan must have regretted the decision, and it might have been a gesture of apology when he invited Y J Rao for the first launch of SLV-3 from Sriharikota on 10 August 1979. Y J Rao did not turn up.

Within a few months of his transfer, Y J Rao quit and migrated to the US. ISRO just lost a potential chairman. Decks were cleared for U R Rao to take over from Dhawan as the ISRO chairman, though it would happen only in 1984.

This history was rankling me when U R Rao sounded evasive about giving a commitment on my elevation as the LPSC director. But when he argued that I cannot leave just when the PSLV had a failed first flight, and that I have to ensure its success, I agreed. With the first flight, I was confident of the success of the second and fourth phases, for which I was the project director, but every launch has to be considered a new venture. We got back to work, putting together the second Viking engine and the smaller fourth-stage liquid engine.

A month before Rao was to retire, on 15 March 1994, I returned to Rao, this time not with a resignation letter but a letter seeking permission to go to